

The Annotation Method

2-HOUR
SESSION

Stop losing marks to silly mistakes: a repeatable structure for every comprehension question

Name: **Mungola**Date: **11 August 2026**Focus: **Annotation skills & question structure**

Marks: ____ / 46

Why this session exists: most marks lost in comprehension aren't lost because you didn't understand the passage — they're lost because you answered the wrong question, forgot to quote, or rushed past a keyword. This session teaches you a fixed method to annotate the text and structure every answer, so those mistakes stop happening.

PART 1 · THE 3-PASS READING METHOD

Every comprehension passage gets read **three times** — never once. Each pass has one job.

1

FIRST PASS

Read the whole passage fast, no annotating. Just get the story: who, where, what happens.

2

SECOND PASS

Read the questions first. Circle the command word and keywords in each one before going back to the text.

3

ANNOTATE

Go paragraph by paragraph, marking evidence using the annotation code below as you find it.

4

ANSWER

Build each answer with the Point → Evidence → Explain chain (Part 3). Never skip the Explain.

THE ANNOTATION CODE — USE THE SAME MARKS EVERY TIME

underline

Evidence that directly answers a question — the exact words you'll quote.

name

Circle every character, place, or time reference — stops you mixing people up.

word

Box any word you're not 100% sure of — check it against the sentence around it.

★ note

Star a margin note wherever the writer implies something without stating it outright — that's an inference clue.

PART 2 · WORKED EXAMPLE — WATCH THE METHOD IN ACTION

Below is a short extract already annotated exactly as you should mark your own passages. Read the margin notes — they show the thinking, not just the marking.

Reuben had checked the timer four times in the last minute, and each time it told him the same thing: eleven minutes left, and the circuit still wasn't drawing power.

Underlined = the key fact the whole extract turns on. If a question asks "how much time did Reuben have left," this is the exact evidence to quote.

Across the hall, Priya's team had already finished testing theirs twice. She caught his eye and gave him a small, apologetic shrug, as if the head start hadn't been her idea at all.

Boxed word: "apologetic" is doing more than describing a shrug — it tells us Priya feels bad about being ahead, which matters for a "what does this suggest about their relationship" question.

Reuben didn't shrug back. He unclipped the battery pack, turned it over, and noticed for the first time that the wire he'd soldered that morning had come away from the terminal — not snapped, just never quite attached.

★ No one says Reuben rushed this morning. But "never quite attached" strongly implies it — that's an inference, not a stated fact. This is exactly the kind of clue a "star" note is for.

THE FIVE SILLY MISTAKES THIS METHOD FIXES

- **Answering the question you expected, not the one asked** — always re-read the exact wording after circling the command word (explain / suggest / how does / why).
- **Forgetting to quote** — if you didn't underline it during annotation, you probably won't remember to include it in your answer. Annotate first, always.
- **Stopping after the quote** — a quote on its own earns 0 marks for an "explain" question. You must add what it shows.
- **Mixing up characters** — circling names during the second pass prevents attributing the wrong action to the wrong person under time pressure.
- **Missing marks that are "worth it"** — a 3-mark question needs three separate, distinct points. Count the marks before you start writing and count your points as you go.

PART 3 · THE POINT → EVIDENCE → EXPLAIN CHAIN

Every answer worth more than one mark follows the same three-step chain. Missing any one step is the single most common way marks are lost.

POINT

State your answer in one clear sentence, directly matching the command word.

EVIDENCE

Quote the exact underlined words from the passage — short and precise, in quotation marks.

EXPLAIN

Say what the quote shows or suggests. This is the step that actually earns the marks.

PART 4 · PRACTICE PASSAGE — "THE LAST CIRCUIT"

ORIGINAL PASSAGE · ANNOTATE THIS YOURSELF BEFORE ANSWERING

¶¹ Reuben had checked the timer four times in the last minute, and each time it told him the same thing: eleven minutes left, and the circuit still wasn't drawing power. Around him, five other teams murmured over breadboards and coils of wire, the low hum of the school hall almost drowning out the countdown clock bolted above the stage.

¶² Across the hall, Priya's team had already finished testing theirs twice. She caught his eye and gave him a small, apologetic shrug, as if the head start hadn't been her idea at all. Reuben knew it hadn't — Priya had wanted to build the simpler circuit from the start, and it was he who had insisted on the version with the extra sensor, the one that impressed judges but left far less room for error.

¶³ He didn't shrug back. He unclipped the battery pack, turned it over, and noticed for the first time that the wire he'd soldered that morning had come away from the terminal — not snapped, just never quite attached. His stomach dropped in a way that had nothing to do with the timer.

¶⁴ "Nine minutes," said Priya quietly, appearing at his elbow with a spare soldering iron already warm in her hand. She didn't ask what was wrong. She simply held the wire steady while he reheated the joint, the two of them working in the kind of silence that didn't need explaining.

¶⁵ When the connection finally held and the small red light on the board blinked on, Reuben let out a breath he hadn't realised he was holding. "You should be testing your own again," he said. Priya shook her head. "Mine already works. Yours needed to." She said it plainly, without any hint that she thought it made her the better engineer — which, Reuben suspected, was exactly why it did.

¶⁶ With four minutes left on the clock, the judges called his team forward. Reuben glanced back once at Priya, who was already re-testing her own circuit as though nothing had happened, and understood that some kinds of help are never meant to be thanked out loud.

PART 5 · QUESTIONS — APPLY THE METHOD

Q1 — Retrieval

1 MARK

How much time was left on the clock when Reuben discovered the loose wire?

Command word check: "how much" — a direct fact, no explanation needed.

Q2 — Vocabulary in context**2 MARKS**

Look at Paragraph 2. Explain what the word "apologetic" suggests about how Priya feels about her team finishing first.

Box the word before answering, then use the Explain step to say what it implies, not just what it means.

Q3 — Inference**3 MARKS**

What does Paragraph 3 suggest about how the loose wire happened, even though the text never states it directly?

Star clue: "never quite attached" — a Point → Evidence → Explain answer, in full.

Q4 — Character relationships**3 MARKS**

Using evidence from Paragraphs 2, 4 and 5, explain what the passage suggests about the relationship between Reuben and Priya.

This needs three separate points across three paragraphs — count them as you write.

Q5 — Language choice**3 MARKS**

Explain the effect of the phrase "his stomach dropped in a way that had nothing to do with the timer" (Paragraph 3).

Two things are being compared here — what feeling is being described, and why is it worse than the time pressure?

Q6 — Structure**3 MARKS**

How does the writer build tension across Paragraphs 1 to 3, before Priya arrives to help in Paragraph 4?

Look at how the timer, the crowd, and the discovery of the loose wire are ordered — is anything getting closer together?

Q7 — Final line interpretation

4 MARKS

What does the final line, "some kinds of help are never meant to be thanked out loud," suggest about Priya's character and about Reuben's understanding of her by the end of the passage?

Two things are being asked — Priya's character, and how Reuben's understanding of her has changed. Answer both.

Q8 — Extended response

6 MARKS

How does the writer use language and structure across the whole passage to show that real teamwork doesn't need to be announced? Support your answer with at least four separate, evidenced points.

Plan before you write: find four different pieces of evidence from four different paragraphs first.

MODEL ANSWERS & MARK SCHEME

Q1 — RETRIEVAL (1 MARK)

- ✓ **Point:** Nine minutes were left when Priya arrived to help — but the loose wire was discovered with eleven minutes left on the clock ("eleven minutes left, and the circuit still wasn't drawing power").

Q2 — VOCABULARY IN CONTEXT (2 MARKS)

- ✓ **Point + Evidence:** "apologetic" suggests Priya feels genuinely uncomfortable about being ahead, not proud or smug about it.
- ✓ **Explain:** this shows she values Reuben's success as much as her own, setting up why she later stops her own testing to help him.

Q3 — INFERENCE (3 MARKS)

- ✓ **Point:** the passage implies Reuben was careless or rushed when soldering the wire that morning.
- ✓ **Evidence:** the wire "had come away from the terminal — not snapped, just never quite attached."
- ✓ **Explain:** "never quite attached" rules out an accident (like snapping) and instead suggests the joint was never done properly in the first place — an inference, since the text never directly says he rushed.

Q4 — CHARACTER RELATIONSHIPS (3 MARKS)

- ✓ **Point 1:** Priya's "apologetic shrug" (¶2) shows she cares about Reuben's feelings, not just winning.
- ✓ **Point 2:** in ¶4, she "didn't ask what was wrong" and simply helped — showing quiet trust and understanding rather than needing to be asked.
- ✓ **Point 3:** in ¶5, she plainly says "Mine already works. Yours needed to" without pride, showing she sees helping him as simply logical, not a favour — reinforcing a relationship built on equality rather than competition.

Q5 — LANGUAGE CHOICE (3 MARKS)

- ✓ **Point:** the phrase compares two kinds of pressure — the time pressure of the countdown, and a deeper emotional pressure (guilt, fear of having ruined his own project).
- ✓ **Evidence:** "nothing to do with the timer" explicitly separates the physical dread from the ticking clock.
- ✓ **Explain:** this shows the reader that Reuben's real fear is about his own mistake and the choice he made (the riskier circuit), not simply about running out of time — deepening his character beyond just "a student under pressure."

Q6 — STRUCTURE (3 MARKS)

- ✓ **Point 1:** the writer opens with the timer already counting down, immediately establishing urgency before any problem is even revealed.
- ✓ **Point 2:** Priya's team finishing "twice" (¶2) is placed directly before the wire problem is discovered (¶3), so the reader feels Reuben falling behind before they even know why.
- ✓ **Point 3:** the short, blunt sentence "His stomach dropped" at the end of ¶3 lands right after the discovery, structurally mirroring the sudden drop in Reuben's confidence — tension peaks right before Priya's rescue in ¶4.

Q7 — FINAL LINE INTERPRETATION (4 MARKS)

- ✓ **Point 1 (character):** the line suggests Priya deliberately avoids drawing attention to her own kindness — she helps because it's right, not to be praised for it.
- ✓ **Point 2 (character):** this fits her earlier plain, unshowy dialogue ("Mine already works. Yours needed to"), confirming a consistent, modest character rather than a one-off act.
- ✓ **Point 3 (Reuben's understanding):** Reuben only "understood" this at the very end, suggesting he hadn't fully appreciated it in the moment — he was too focused on the crisis to notice.
- ✓ **Point 4 (Reuben's understanding):** the fact that he "glanced back" before realising this shows a shift from simply receiving help to properly recognising what it cost her — a small but real moment of growth in his character.

Q8 — EXTENDED RESPONSE (6 MARKS, INDICATIVE CONTENT)

- ✓ **Point 1:** Priya's help is offered without being asked ("She didn't ask what was wrong"), showing teamwork that doesn't need to be requested or acknowledged to happen.
- ✓ **Point 2:** her dialogue throughout is short and unemotional ("Nine minutes," "Mine already works") — the plainness of her language mirrors how ordinary and unremarkable she wants the help to seem, even though it clearly isn't.
- ✓ **Point 3:** structurally, Priya returns to testing her own circuit immediately afterwards "as though nothing had happened" (¶6) — the writer deliberately shows her moving on without expecting thanks, reinforcing the passage's final idea.
- ✓ **Point 4:** the final line itself ("some kinds of help are never meant to be thanked out loud") is a generalisation that lifts the story beyond just these two characters, suggesting this is a wider truth about real teamwork the writer wants the reader to take away.
- ✓ (Full marks require four genuinely distinct, evidenced points spanning different paragraphs — reward any well-evidenced point in this spirit, not only these four.)